



The Digital World

A Round-up Of Technology News From Across The Globe

UNITED STATES

Christmas wish-lists of kids today aren't neatly-typed letters to Santa anymore. For example, 11-year-old Katie Johnsen in DC got tech-savvy and turned her list into a Power-Point presentation with a red and green background, a picture of Santa, and links to the sites where her items could be bought!



UNITED KINGDOM

The UK's largest robotics laboratory is set to open—in a bid to rival institutions in the US and Japan. The new facility in Bristol hopes to develop intelligent robots designed to work with people and be able to carry out tasks independently.



MEXICO

"North American country" seems a misnomer for Mexico. According to a recent survey, only 16.5 per cent of the population has a PC, and only 9 per cent has any Internet connection at all. Compare this with the 50 per cent broadband penetration in the United States, just across the border!

THE UAE

Despite being the most progressive of the Arab nations (think Dubai!), the UAE blocks nearly all pornography, gambling, and illegal drugs sites. The state also blocks access to all Israeli sites and even English-language dating sites.

JAPAN

Japanese universities have decided to include student ID cards on students' phones. From April, new students at Kanagawa Institute of Technology will carry an ID on their phone that lets them register for classes, open locked doors and such.

SOUTH KOREA

Some estimates peg the number of online gamers in Korea at 70 to 80 per cent of the population! The South Korean government therefore keeps a close watch on online gaming, announcing in December '05 a "set of measures" to "crack down on increasing hacking attacks on online game items."

incident. So what is the real story?

Science journal *Nature* chose 50 science articles from both encyclopaedias, and gave peer reviewers a blind test to find mistakes. Britannica turned up 123 errors, and Wikipedia 162. To quantify that, the quality of information from Wikipedia was 25 per cent worse.

Whatever such figures may say, the questions remain. On the one hand, anyone with knowledge of a certain topic can contribute to Wikipedia, and who would want to mess with an entry if he didn't know too much about the topic? On the other hand, what about opinionated people, who put up entries posing as facts but which merely reflect an opinion? Then there's the question of policing: with hundreds of entries coming in every day, who's to check them all? What about quality of writing, and consistency? How can Wikipedia possibly be cited, when one knows that the material could be merely something

someone at the other end of the world casually wrote? And yet, one still needs to ask, what can possibly be wrong about a project that aims to bring together, onto one platform, the collective knowledge that we as a species possess?

We would like to hear from you on this issue—do write in!

WILL THE IDEA LAST?

Sprint Brings Movies To The Mobile

Sprint's movie content provider MSpot said on 12 December that the global voice, data and Internet service provider had soft-launched its MSpot Movies service in November 2005, featuring 10 full-length films customers can stream to their Vision phones serially in five-minute increments.



Three Incredibly Useful Sites

Et Cetera

www.deraradio.com



Deraradio.com

A hot spot for music buffs, DeraRadio.com is an on-demand Internet radio station. The site's database includes Western, Arabic and Hindi music, and the latest numbers. All you need is Real Player. There are also online dedications, request shows and the popular Derachat.

www.nivalink.com



Nivalink.com

A Web-based hotel reservations firm, Nivalink.com has put together more than 1,000 holiday options within India with details on each such as location, accommodation, transport, latest tariff, facilities, meals and so on, with actual photos. The site has profiled over 100 weekend retreats, beach getaways, hill stations, health resorts, and star cruises among others. It's definitely worth checking out!

www.nasscom.org



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